



— Academy

BOE Preparation

APPEALS

CORE

Walk into the Board of Equalization with a defense the board can adopt.

THE PROBLEM

What you're facing

A property owner has appealed the assessed value to the Board of Equalization. You have limited time to assemble a defense that holds up under questioning.

WHY IT MATTERS

What's at stake

The burden of supporting the value is on the assessor. A weak or disorganized defense gets values reduced on the record, sets precedent neighbors cite, and signals which assessments are soft.

THE MENTAL MODEL

How experts think

Experts prepare the board's decision, not just their own file. They ask: "What is the single clearest piece of evidence that this value is correct, and what is the owner's strongest counter?" They concede the genuinely weak points early and anchor on the comparable sales and the equity (uniformity) argument the board can actually act on.

Workflow

1. Restate the owner's claimed value and the specific basis for it.
2. Pull 3-5 qualified comparable sales and adjust them transparently.
3. Run the equity check: how is this parcel assessed relative to similar parcels?
4. Identify and pre-answer the owner's strongest argument.
5. Assemble a one-page summary the board can follow without you narrating.

Common mistakes

Bringing data instead of a conclusion.

Ignoring the owner's best argument until they raise it at the hearing.

Using unadjusted or unqualified "comps."

Defending the process instead of the value.

Tools

Comparable sales set Subject property record card Neighborhood ratio/equity data Photos and permit history

DO THIS NEXT

Now What?

- 1 Build the one-page board summary first; let it dictate what evidence you actually need.
- 2 Rehearse the concession + anchor: what you give up, and what you stand on.
- 3 Have the equity exhibit ready even if you don't lead with it.

Further reading: WA DOR Appe

